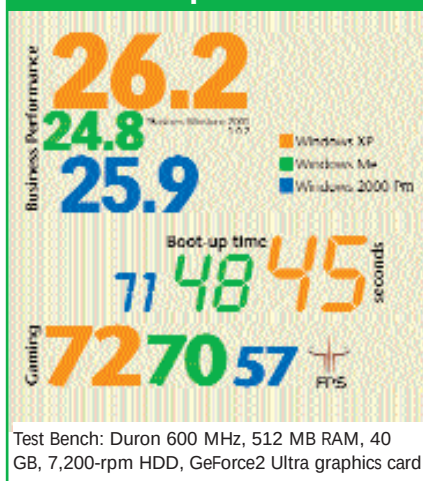


Exposed



machine can be cross-checked with the details from the previous installation when it goes through activation. If the two machines differ greatly, XP won't receive the activation code it needs to run beyond the 30-day deadline.

In short, Microsoft is enforcing the rule of 'one PC for one OS'. So does this mean that changing your configuration around a bit or adding new hardware is going to make XP think it's a totally different machine? Not necessarily. Microsoft says that you can make a maximum of six hardware changes at a time without needing XP to re-activate. Needless to say, as with every attempt at curbing piracy, the cracks for product activation have already started appearing.

XP+

Can we please be spared the hidden expenses? In case you haven't been observing the way Microsoft 'follows-up' with their consumer level OSes, a Plus! Pack usually rears its expensive head

with each upgrade of Windows. Essentially, a Plus! Pack is nothing more than a few enhancements that effectively turn Windows XP into TP (time pass).

Wallpapers, themes, media add-ons and things of this nature will end up costing you money, that too for something you could get for free on the Net. A few games are featured as well but they really don't hold any ground against what you can download. Plus, the featured games are trial versions only, usually put there in the hope that maybe somebody would be gullible enough to pay and get fully functional versions!

Instead of wasting your money on this, be smart and invest in upgrading that memory in your machine which XP is going to hog.

Actual additions

As a true value addition, XP's integration for basic applications comes as a definite plus for home and business users alike. Among the bundled perks is Windows Messenger, the instant messaging client that competes with the likes of Yahoo! and ICQ.

Windows Media Player has been a regular with Windows since the release of Windows 95. However, Microsoft chose to integrate more functionality into Media Player, making redundant alternative solutions look too expensive and not purchase-worthy.

64-bit

Looking beyond the realm of personal and business PCs, Microsoft also features a 64-bit edition of the XP operating system. It's designed for extremely powerful machines with a 64-bit processor, specifically the Intel Itanium. This version is exclusively written and optimised for

Too Expensive?

Windows XP continues the trend of incorporating new applications into the OS. It includes several new applications such as compression software, a firewall, movie making software, a media player and CD writing software. Does that mean we are seeing the death of the application market with all software being integrated into the OS itself? Not really. The integrated applications are not very feature rich. The CD-writing feature, for instance, doesn't allow

you to work with different file formats and other advanced options. The media player does not allow the digital audio encoding in the MP3 format.

The claim of damage done to software makers is slightly exaggerated. The application package with XP does provide enough functionality for most users, but for those who want more control over what they do, the free market is the only place.

Exploit to the Max

- 1 Place frequently used application on the top of your Start menu by right-clicking the link and selecting Pin to Start Menu.
- 2 If your mouse has a scroll wheel, you can change the size of fonts in Web pages on the fly by scrolling up to enlarge the text and scrolling down to decrease the size, while holding down the [Ctrl] key.
- 3 Windows XP has support for ClearType—Microsoft's anti-aliasing font display technology—but doesn't have it enabled by default. It's worth trying as it makes reading easier. To enable ClearType, right-click on the desktop, select Properties, Appearance, Effects, select ClearType from the second drop-down menu and enable the selection. Expect best results on laptop displays.
- 4 By default, Windows Explorer opens up showing the contents in the My Documents folder. To change the default folder, click **Start > Programs > Accessories**. Right-click on Windows Explorer and click Properties. Under the Target field, change `%SystemRoot%\explorer.exe` to `%SystemRoot%\explorer.exe /n,/e,/select,C:\`. This allows you to view all the folders and files in the C root directory.
- 5 If running older applications is a problem in Windows XP, invoke Compatibility Mode for that particular program. Right-click on its .exe file and select **Properties > Compatibility** and select the OS and display settings that you want. Clicking on OK will ensure that the program works as intended.
- 6 You can revert to the default look of Windows. Right-click on the desktop and go to the Themes tab. Select the Windows classic theme and click on OK. To change the appearance of the Start Menu, right-click on the Taskbar and select Properties. Select the Start Menu tab, and check the option for the Classic Start Menu. Click on OK for the settings to take effect.
- 7 Remove all the icons from your desktop. Right-click on the desktop and select Properties. Go to the Desktop tab and uncheck the options for displaying the regular desktop icons such as Recycle Bin.